SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #94 · CHURCH & AUTHORITY

“Family problems must be kept secret to protect the church.”

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Where it often comes from

Being told not to “air dirty laundry” or hurt the church’s reputation. Pressure to protect a leader or respected family. Fear of shame, gossip, or being blamed. Families where abuse, addiction, or affairs were hidden. Teaching that honesty about problems is disloyal.

What Scripture teaches

God loves truth and light. Scripture tells believers to expose deeds of darkness, not cover them. Whoever conceals sin will not prosper, but whoever confesses and turns from it finds mercy. God calls His people to defend the weak and rescue the oppressed. Private matters can be handled with discretion, but secrecy that protects harm is never God’s way. Protecting people, especially the vulnerable, matters more to God than protecting appearances.

> *“Have no fellowship with the fruitless deeds of darkness, but rather expose them”* **(Ephesians 5:11)**.

Also see

> “He who conceals his sins will not prosper, but whoever confesses and renounces them will find mercy” **(Proverbs 28:13)**.

> “Defend the cause of the weak and fatherless; uphold the rights of the afflicted and oppressed. Rescue the weak and needy; save them from the hand of the wicked” **(Psalm 82:3–4)**.

> “For there is nothing hidden that will not be disclosed, and nothing concealed that will not be made known and brought to light” **(Luke 8:17)**.

> “Carry one another’s burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ” **(Galatians 6:2)**.

Common self-statements

- If I tell anyone, I’ll hurt the church.
- We have to look like a good Christian family.
- Talking about this would be gossip.
- God wants me to protect our reputation.
- It’s disloyal to ask for help.
- If I speak up, I’ll be blamed.

Common logical errors

- **Misplaced loyalty:** Valuing reputation above people’s safety and healing.
- **Confusing discretion with secrecy:** Treating honest help-seeking as gossip.
- **Fear-based thinking:** Staying silent because of fear of consequences.
- **Discounting harm:** Minimizing the damage that secrecy allows to continue.

Challenging questions

- What does Ephesians 5:11 say to do with deeds of darkness?
- Does keeping this secret protect people or protect harm?
- Is anyone in danger, especially a child?
- What is the difference between privacy and secrecy that hides wrongdoing?
- What does God say about defending the weak and oppressed?
- Who is a safe person I could tell?
- What would healing look like for my family?

Truth summary

> Family problems do not have to be kept secret to protect the church. God loves truth and light, and He cares about the weak and hurting. I can handle private matters with discretion and still seek help. When someone is being harmed, speaking up is right. Healing begins when what is hidden is brought into the light.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Truth
- Child Abuse/Neglect
- Marriage Guidance
- Help
- Church

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Communication
- Marriage
- Parenting

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> **Overcoming Anxiety** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Family problems must be kept secret to protect the church"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Family problems must be kept secret to protect the church." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What should I do with deeds of darkness?
- ☐ Does secrecy protect people or harm?
- ☐ Is anyone in danger?
- ☐ Privacy or secrecy that hides wrong: which is this?
- ☐ What does God say about the weak and oppressed?
- ☐ Who is a safe person I could tell?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God loves truth and light.
- ☐ Protecting people matters more than protecting appearances.
- ☐ Seeking help is not disloyalty.
- ☐ God calls me to defend the weak.
- ☐ Whoever confesses and turns from sin finds mercy.
- ☐ Healing begins when hidden things come into the light.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Ephesians 5:11**
  "Have no fellowship with the fruitless deeds of darkness, but rather expose them."
- [ ] **Proverbs 28:13**
  "He who conceals his sins will not prosper, but whoever confesses and renounces them will find mercy."
- [ ] **Psalm 82:3–4**
  "Defend the cause of the weak and fatherless; uphold the rights of the afflicted and oppressed. Rescue the weak and needy; save them from the hand of the wicked."
- [ ] **Luke 8:17**
  "For there is nothing hidden that will not be disclosed, and nothing concealed that will not be made known and brought to light."
- [ ] **Galatians 6:2**
  "Carry one another's burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Truth journal:** Each day, write one true thing about my family's situation and one step toward help or healing.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, John 8:32 becomes: "Then **Sarah** will know the truth, and the truth will set **her** free."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Truth" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Tell one safe person outside your family** what is really happening.
- ☐ **Meet with a Christian counselor** to talk through your family situation.
- ☐ **If anyone is being abused or is in danger, contact the authorities.** In the U.S., the National Domestic Violence Hotline is 1-800-799-7233 and the Childhelp hotline is 1-800-422-4453. In an emergency, call 911.
- ☐ **Read Psalm 82 and Isaiah 1:17,** and write what God says about defending the vulnerable.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Family problems must be kept secret to protect the church": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One step toward help or healing
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Family problems must be kept secret to protect the church.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, You love truth and light. Help me reject the lie that family problems must be kept secret to protect the church. Give me courage to seek help, wisdom to know whom to tell, and strength to protect anyone who is being hurt. Bring healing to my family. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.